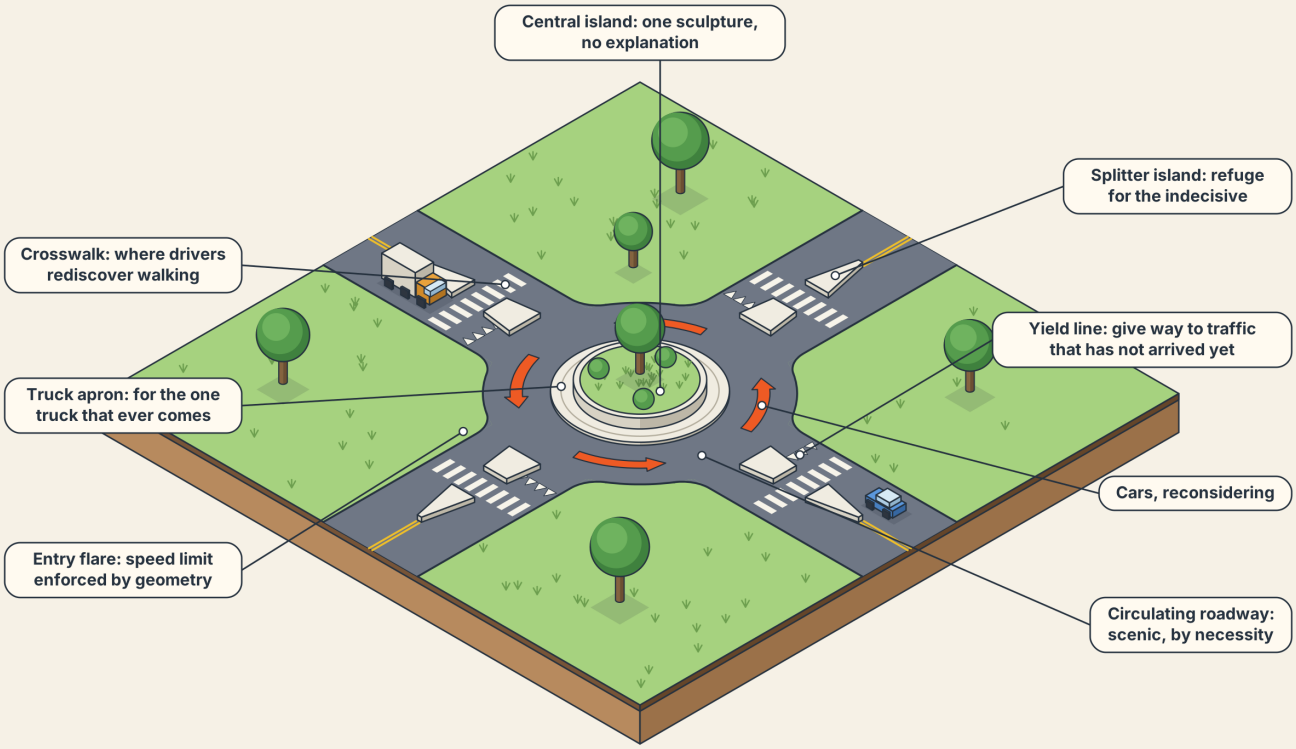
A FIELD GUIDE TO THE REVERSE ROBERT MOSES EFFECT

# How to Make a Roundabout Completely Non-Functional

Conventional wisdom says a roundabout exists to move cars. This is a misunderstanding. Robert Moses built expressways to relieve congestion, and the expressways filled; economists later named the effect *induced demand*. The reverse Moses effect runs the same law backward: add enough friction and some trips simply never happen. Planners call it traffic evaporation. Everyone else calls it “I’ll just get lunch near work.” A roundabout is that friction, poured in concrete. The goal is not throughput. The goal is for a driver to arrive, yield, circle once, and quietly reconsider the trip.




## Six steps to a fully non-functional roundabout

**1. Maximize deflection.** Fast roundabouts are a design failure. Aim for entry speeds a brisk cyclist would call reasonable, so every driver briefly meets the geometry of their own choices.

**2. Yield to everyone.** Entering drivers give way to circulating traffic, and to traffic that has not yet arrived, and, on a good day, to the concept of traffic.

**3. Landscape with conviction.** A raised, planted island with one sculpture and no explanation draws the eye and nothing else. Do not make it a shortcut.

**4. Invite pedestrians.** Set the crosswalk back a car length and add an actual pedestrian. Drivers who must stop for a human being often remember they own shoes.

**5. Add a second lane. Do not explain it.** Lane choice is a form of calming. A driver in the wrong lane gets a free scenic tour of the circle.

**6. Sign everything.** “Yield,” “Keep right,” “Counterclockwise,” a small pictogram of a tree. A driver reading all of them is no longer moving.

**The plan’s one flaw:** roundabouts keep working. A four-way roundabout has 8 conflict points where a conventional intersection has 32 (FHWA), serious-injury crashes tend to fall sharply, and many move more cars per hour than the signal they replaced. If your goal is truly zero throughput, you will need a bollard. **Success metric:** coffee shop revenue near the circle.

Satire. No roundabouts were harmed in the making of this document. Illustration: Civil Plain Sight isometric style.